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Independent outfits are opening at a pace not seen in years. The new format is smaller, more curated, more local, and the business is increasingly bolstered by cafés and events

IS IT INDIA'S BOOKSTORE MOMENT?

Swati Daftuar

There's been a sharp rise in the number of independent bookstores across Indian cities. They are visible, talked about, and often beloved. But dig deeper and this 'revival' of the physical bookstore reveals complicated layers. In Bengaluru last month, when a sudden and intense hailstorm flooded the iconic Bookworm on Church Street, nearly 5,000 books worth an estimated ₹14 lakh were damaged. Hundreds of the city's reading community showed up in solidarity, to help

clean and dry the water-damaged books. Together with publishers and well-known authors such as historian Ramachandra Guha, they urged their followers on social media to buy the books and help offset losses. It was a vivid reminder that the independent bookstore is not merely a space of retail, but one that has the capacity to gather around it a community.

The uplifting moment, however, sits uncomfortably beside another story – that of Fort Kochi's Printed Matter. Just 10 days after I spoke to founder Gouri Ramkumar, I came across an announcement on their Instagram page. The bookstore, it said, would be closing its physical store on May 10. "The seasonal



nature of Fort Kochi [where the tourist season dropped away once summer set in] and the economics of independent bookselling make it hard to keep a physical storefront going," the post read. This revealed a sobering truth: that a store can become part of the cultural life of a city and still find its physical existence untenable.

West vs. India
Meanwhile, in the U.S. and the U.K., the bookstore story is being framed as a comeback – fuelled in part by social media and younger readers, but also by stronger retail infrastructure and large chains reinventing themselves. Barnes & Noble, the leading retail bookstore chain in the U.S., recently stated on its website that it opened more new bookstores in 2025 than in the whole decade from 2009 to 2019, and that it would open over 60 new ones this year.
So, how is the story different in India, which has seen many launches recently: from Fictionary in Mumbai to Luna in Hyderabad, Beku and Turning Pages in Bengaluru, Mehrab in Kochi, The Raven Academy in Chennai, and Ukiyo in Imphal? Bookstore chain Sapna says it runs more than 24 large-format shops across the country. Crossword announced it would expand from 120 stores (across 40 cities) to over 150 by the end of 2025, and increase their revenue from ₹275 crore to ₹400 crore in 2026.
Legacy owners in the country are circumspect in calling it a comeback. Leonard Fernandes, who runs Dogears in Goa, for instance, admits that his store, founded in 2016 and known for its curated selection of books on local history, culture and fiction, is only now breaking even. They are waiting to see if the trend proves to be sustainable.

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ELITE MATRIMONY

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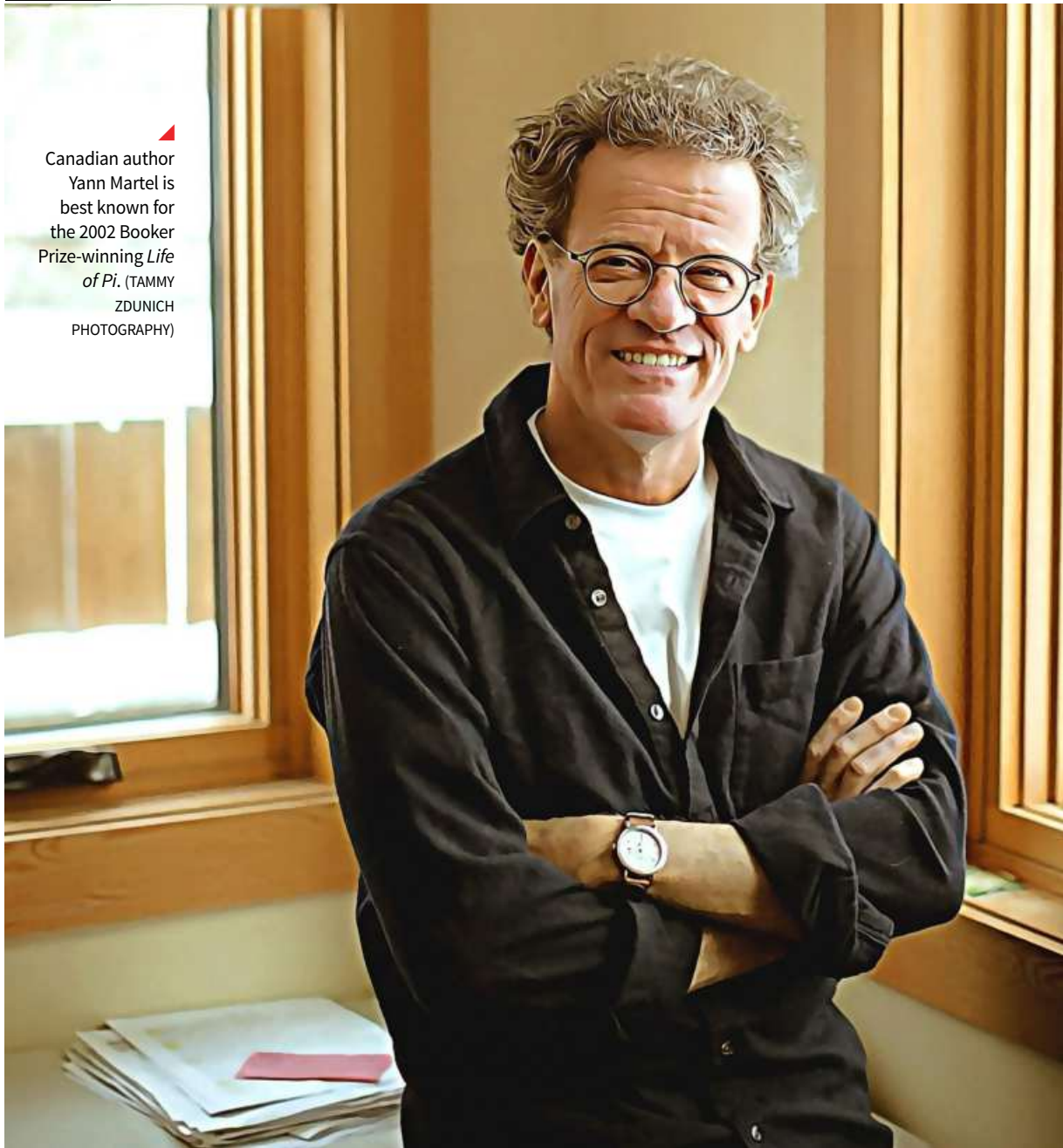
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Canadian author
Yann Martel is
best known for
the 2002 Booker
Prize-winning *Life of Pi*. (TAMMY
ZDUNICH
PHOTOGRAPHY)

Vasudevan Mukunth
mukunth.v@thehindu.co.in

In his first novel in a decade, Canadian author Yann Martel – best known for the 2002 Booker Prize-winning *Life of Pi* – explores the animus of the Trojan War through a fragile marriage. But *Son of Nobody* (Canongate) is also much more than that. Martel narrates the two tales and the bridges between them as a translation of a fictitious new myth – “The Psoad” – and its footnotes. The result is an inventive meditation on myth, memory and the stories people tell to survive disappointment. Excerpts from an interview:

Question: In *Life of Pi*, the revelation that Pi’s story might be a fantasy arrives as a shock. In *Son of Nobody*, the hints that Harlow, the protagonist, may be projecting “The Psoad” accumulate from early on. Did you want the reader to suspect Harlow sooner than they suspected Pi?
Answer: In *Life of Pi*, I wanted to point out in stark terms that life can be read in radically different ways. In this case, either in a flatly possible way [the story without animals], or in a less plausible, more satisfyingly colourful way [but just as harrowing – the story with animals]. I wanted to present that choice only at the end, when all the evidence, so to speak, was presented. In *Son of Nobody*, it isn’t a question of choice. “The Psoad”, the lost Trojan War epic at the

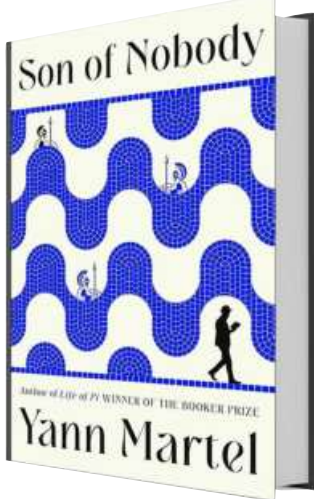
IN CONVERSATION THE WEIGHT OF MYTH

Why *Life of Pi* author
Yann Martel blends Homeric
myth with the breakdown of a
marriage in his new novel

centre of the novel, isn’t a replacement for *The Iliad*; it’s rather a supplement. The two stories aren’t in competition, as they are in *Life of Pi*. As I point out in the novel, *The Iliad* is a myth, with no historical facts to back it. Throughout the novel, I remind the reader of this. The intent is not to diminish Homer but rather to point out that *The Iliad*’s underpinnings are no more solid than those of “The Psoad”. Both stories are myths. That being so, I didn’t want to claim in the novel that Harlow’s discovery rested on a solid archaeological find, because that’s beside the point. A newfangled story is no less true [or false] than an old myth.

Q: Michael Greenstein noticed in The

Seaboard Review that you might have named the soldier Psoas, author of “The Psoad” in your book, after Fernando Pessoa, and Pessoa was a poet of invented selves who could say what the author couldn’t. What is it that the ancient soldier can bear that Harlow can’t?
A: What a lovely near-coincidence, what a proof that a reader co-creates a text! I think neither Psoas nor Harlow Donne can bear their fates, to have all their dreams wrecked, to have everything come to nothing. The only thing left hanging is destination. Psoas ends up a living man in Hell. Where will Harlow end up? Perhaps it is that Psoas has arrived where Harlow is heading – unless Harlow can stir himself and move forward on that other foot of Western



consciousness, its other foundational myth, the story of Jesus. That is how the West has walked, one foot Troy/wrath, the other foot Jesus/love.

Q: You’ve said that you wanted to give the footnote a starring role. But footnotes are by definition subordinate and there’s an inherent tension between that lowly position and the emotional weight Harlow’s commentary eventually carries. Is there a reason you’ve literally pushed the commoner’s voice to the bottom?
A: History and institutions loom over us, can loom over us, all of them telling us that we are small and of little consequence – but does that diminish the emotional weight each of us carries within ourselves? And is it not so that history is made, institutions can stand, individuals can dominate, only through the collective will, understanding and consent of their constituent parts? The big is made up of the small. To give a starring role to footnotes and to Psoas of Midea, the son of nobody, is to give a starring role to the essential ordinary citizen, in life as in print. Your plaint of a commoner’s voice being “pushed... to the bottom” refers to older texts, older times.

Q: Son of Nobody asks the breakdown of a marriage to bear the weight of the Trojan War. When you decided to mirror a decade-long siege in a couple falling apart, how did you think about the risk that the domestic would trivialise the epic?
A: What would be the point of mirroring an old war with a modern war? That might be of interest to historians of war: the evolution of military technology, changes in field tactics, the study of strategic triumphs and failures, and so on. But few of us today experience war first-hand, so to dwell on two wars would exclude the life experience of most readers. They would just read from the outside. Better to parallel something they might actually know, and a relationship falling apart, a couple at war with itself, that is something most people know, or can intuit. Anyway, whether you’re in hell because you’ve been to war literally – against the Trojans – or metaphorically – against your wife or husband – you’re in hell. And you can’t really trivialise a myth; you can only fail to make it your own.

Rewriting the superhero

Falah Faisal’s *Musalman* is a witty alternative to conventional comic narratives

Chintan Girish Modi

If you are fed up with dragging yourself through a joyless slog of serious political tomes, give *Musalman* a chance to surprise you. Written by Falah Faisal and illustrated by Spud, this graphic novel is for readers who like their politics loud and proud, served with biting satire. It follows the journey of its eponymous superhero as he battles the Coronavirus, the 10-headed king Raavan, priest-politician Dhongi Ji, and primetime anchor Arnab Cowswamy on Dictatorship TV. Creating a Muslim superhero seems a radical act in a country where mainstream discourse expects Muslims to fit stereotypes. On one end of the spectrum, they are portrayed as villains, based on claims that they are descendants of Mughal invaders, or illegal migrants from Bangladesh, or tricksters waging a so-called love jihad to convert unsuspecting Hindus to Islam.

On the other end, they are depicted as victims, subjected to hate speech, forced to live in ghettos, and falsely accused of spreading terror. In the latter case, they end up becoming a homogenous group stripped of agency, and a cause for liberal saviours to champion.

Musalman is a refreshing alternative, conceived by filmmaker and comedian Faisal, who began with the question “What if there was a Muslim superhero?” and a formula he reveals in the Afterword: “Take the mythos of a classic hero, flip the setting, and see what truths emerge.”

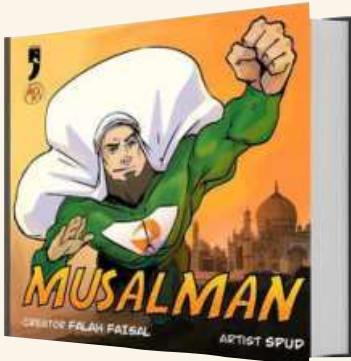
What you get is a non-violent superhero with a “skull-cape”, a sense of humour, and a chiselled body. He wears orange briefs over a green bodysuit, and a beard that extends into a mask. Spud’s boisterous images leave little to the imagination, featuring cameos by lookalikes of contemporary politicians. There is an explicit mention of “communal riots” in the early 2000s.

Mixing horror and comedy
Faisal’s imaginative universe borrows freely from history and mythology. It is not a slave to logic or linearity. He has no qualms about putting unrelated elements – B.R. Ambedkar, musician David Bowie and

businessman Elon Musk – together to see what reaction they elicit.

The mythological Raavan, whose heads are buried in “secret locations across the earth”, makes a comeback to destroy mosques and Mughal architecture. Horror and comedy sit beside each other in this book. When things get too complicated, drug-induced fantasies catalyse easy resolutions. This is the kind of book you read for vibes and laughs, not for sophistication of craft.

The Afterword marks a distinct shift in style, taking on a more sober and introspective tone. At the inaugural Indie Comix Fest in Kozhikode in 2024, just as Faisal put on the *Musalman* costume, he heard the sound of the *azaan* from the neighbourhood mosque.



Musalman
Falah Faisal; illus: Spud
Yoda Press
₹786

“For an atheist looking for proof of god’s existence, there could have been no better sign,” adds the man influenced by comic book writers such as Mark Millar, Harvey Pekar and Alan Moore.

However, the blurb claiming that *Musalman* is “India’s first Muslim Superhero” is misleading. Faiza Ahmad Khan’s film *Supermen of Malegaon* (2008) documents the work of Shaikh Nasir, a wedding videographer who remakes *Superman*, with the story set in Malegaon, a small town in Maharashtra. Faisal’s formula works well but he is, by no means, the first one to do this.

The writer and literary critic’s work has appeared in the anthologies Clear Hold Build and Fearless Love.

The winning novel, originally written in Mandarin Chinese, is a story about queer love and food

Taiwanese Travelogue wins Intl Booker

Radhika Santhanam

A story about Taiwanese food and love between two women has won the International Booker Prize 2026. Taiwanese writer Yáng Shuāng-zi’s *Taiwanese Travelogue*, translated from the Mandarin Chinese by Lin King, is experimental in form. It contains a scholarly foreword, afterwords, fictional footnotes, and real translator’s notes. The novel begins in 1938. Aoyama Chizuko, a Japanese novelist from Nagasaki, arrives in Taiwan, a Japanese colony, on a

government-sponsored tour. Disinterested in the official events or the imperialist agenda, she instead decides to explore Taiwan through its food, guided by her voracious appetite. She befriends a charming and reserved Taiwanese woman, Chizuru, who serves as both her interpreter and an exceptional cook. Chizuko becomes deeply fond of her companion, even urging her to break off her engagement, but Chizuru maintains a distance. Whether she returns Chizuko’s feelings is the question that propels the novel forward. Their relationship – shaped by their different class backgrounds, with



Author Yáng Shuāng-zi (left) and translator Lin King pose with the trophies at Tate Modern in London (GETTY IMAGES)

one woman a ‘Mainlander’ and the other an ‘Islander’ – reflects the complex dynamics of power.

The £50,000 prize was announced by Natasha Brown, chair of the 2026 judges, at a ceremony at London’s Tate Modern on May 19. The committee said, “*Taiwan Travelogue* pulls off an incredible double feat: it succeeds as both a romance and an incisive postcolonial novel. As judges, we’ve enjoyed rich discussions about the many layers of this book. It’s a captivating, slyly sophisticated novel.”

The novel is Yáng’s first to be translated into English and the first translation from the Mandarin Chinese to win the International Booker Prize. This is also the second consecutive International Booker Prize for the independent press, And Other Stories, which took home the prize for *Heart Lamp* last year.

Yáng is a Taiwanese writer of fiction, essays, manga, and video game scripts. King is a Taiwanese-American writer and translator.

Taiwanese writer Yáng Shuāng-zi’s novel is experimental in form. It contains a scholarly foreword, afterwords, fictional footnotes, and real translator’s notes



▶ (Clockwise from far left) A still from *Amma Ariyan*; G. Aravindan; a still from *Swayamvaram*; John Abraham; a still from *Joji*; and Adoor Gopalakrishnan. (R. RAVINDRAN, IMDB, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



Filmmakers Adoor Gopalakrishnan and Kulathoor Bhaskaran Nair kindled the film society movement by launching the first film society in Kerala in 1965



brought with it the agrarian and workers' movements, and a cultural churn that birthed political street plays, songs, literature and cinema. Playwright Thoppil Bhasi, who would later go on to write and direct several popular films, wrote the play *Ningalenne Communistakki* ('You Made Me a Communist', which was later made into a movie) in 1952, aiding in the spread of leftist ideology among the masses.

Five years later, the first democratically elected communist government in the world came to power in Kerala. Although the government soon fell to protests led by revanchist forces, the changes that it initiated, including land and educational reforms, set the stage for drastic improvements in human development indicators. These were taken forward under successive Congress and Left governments. These improved social indices also created a fertile ground for more activities in the cultural sphere. One of the cultural activities that would have a lasting impact on Malayalam cinema was the film

society movement, which filmmaker Adoor Gopalakrishnan (still seven years away from his debut film *Swayamvaram*) and his associate Kulathoor Bhaskaran Nair kindled by launching the first film society in Kerala in 1965. The movement spread, with film societies springing up across towns and villages where the best of world cinema were screened week after week, changing forever the way many would look at the medium of cinema. It eventually led to the emergence of the new wave in Malayalam cinema, with Adoor again leading from the front with *Swayamvaram* in 1972. It explored the human condition with stark realism, in contrast to the majority of escapist fare and staid family dramas in vogue then. The same year witnessed the debut of John Abraham, another avant-garde filmmaker, with *Vidarthikale Ithile Ithile*, and two years later, G. Aravindan came on the scene with *Uttarayanam*. Before long, another set of filmmakers tried to bring together the best elements from popular films and parallel films, creating what came to be known as middle cinema, with filmmakers such as K.G. George, Padmarajan and Bharathan becoming its most popular torchbearers in the 1970s and '80s. Literary giants like M.T. Vasudevan Nair and a crop of young screenwriters, including John Paul and A.K Lohithadas conjured up screenplays that explored the complexity of relationships and inherent frailties of the human mind.

Middle Cinema days
The roots of the current new wave in Malayalam cinema, which began to take shape over the past decade, can be traced back to the Middle Cinema days – be it in the approach to the art form or in the kind of themes chosen. There is little surprise there, for many of the current crop of filmmakers grew up watching the works of these past masters. In fact, one can draw a direct line from Dileesh Pothan's *Joji* (2021), hailed by *The New Yorker* as one of the most remarkable films of the pandemic period, to K.G. George's classic *Irakal* (1985), set in the Emergency era. Yet, these remarkable classics from the yesteryears of Malayalam cinema as well as some of the greatest mainstream hits of the 1980s and '90s still remain largely unknown outside Kerala, partly because it is still a struggle to find good English-subtitled prints of many of them.

An edited excerpt from Ticket to Kerala: The Story of Malayalam Cinema (Rupa Publications India).

BEGINNINGS OF MALAYALAM CINEMA

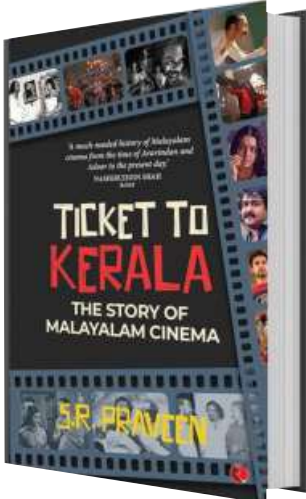
How Kerala's social and political transformations shaped a distinct film tradition

S.R. Praveen

Looking through a number of films in recent years, the Malayalam industry would appear to be treading a slightly different path from the ones other regional film industries or their bigger cousin, Bollywood, are taking. Part of the reason could be the fact that Kerala has often struck an alternate path. For a State that Swami Vivekananda described as 'a lunatic asylum' in the 1890s – frustrated by the shocking levels of caste discrimination and untouchability in Malayali society back then, and where feudal lords held sway – the changes that would come in later years were quite drastic. These changes did not happen organically, but were hard-fought-for through years of struggle, right from the Channar Revolt of women of the Nadar caste (for the right to wear clothes over their upper bodies), to the struggles led by social reformers Ayyankali, Sree Narayana Guru, V.T. Bhattathiripad, Sahodaran Ayyappan and others against discriminatory practices and to ensure equal access for all castes

and genders to public spaces, including roads and temples. Some missionaries also played their part in loosening the hold of the oppressors, beginning with their role in forcing the erstwhile Travancore state to abolish slavery in the 1850s to their efforts to impart education to the oppressed castes, who were often kept away from schools. The after-effects of epochal events such as the Vaikom Satyagraha (1924) and Guruvayur Satyagraha (1931), both non-violent protests to demand the entry of the oppressed castes into temples and public spaces around it, continued to reverberate around Kerala for decades to come. **Ill-fated adventures** During this period, Malayalam cinema was taking its baby steps, with J.C. Daniel making the first-ever film in that language, *Vigathakumaran*, in 1930. Right from the early days, family dramas and social themes were far more in number, compared to the rare mythological films, which made up the majority in other industries. Many of the early endeavours in Malayalam cinema were ill-fated adventures of individuals, who

pooled all their money to make their dream movie. In the initial years, films were not made in big numbers. Even after 1930, many years went by without a single movie being made, until the first of the locally born studios entered the business. Communism came to the shores of Kerala in the 1930s, which



Ticket to Kerala: The Story of Malayalam Cinema
S.R. Praveen
Rupa Publications India
₹499

Prathmesh Kher

In Maharashtra, many posters of Dr. B.R. Ambedkar carry the word *Mahamanav* (Great Man) beneath his image. The association with Friedrich Nietzsche's *Übermensch* (Overman or Superman) is not entirely lost to an attentive examiner. It is, however, a somewhat impudent comparison. Ambedkar repudiated the Nietzschean concept of the Overman as he saw it as a justification for oppression and social inequality. Moreover, Ambedkar detested Nietzsche's admiration for the *Gesetzbuch des Manu* – the *Manusmriti*. These contradictions are precisely what Ankit Kawade, a doctoral candidate at Johns Hopkins University, explores in his debut work *The Ambedkar-Nietzsche Provocations: The Genius of the Chandala and the Gospel of the Superman*.

Walking a fine line
The central provocation of the book is terminological. In the late 1880s, Nietzsche called Christianity a "Chandala religion," borrowing the Sanskrit term for those belonging to the so-called lowest castes of society. Decades later, Ambedkar called Hinduism "the gospel of the superman," repurposing Nietzsche's own coinage against hierarchical order. Kawade begins by excavating Nietzsche's 'Chandala' in close detail. Who is this figure? Chandala is a metaphor for degeneracy, a philosophical cudgel against Christian egalitarianism, stripped entirely of the lived horror it signifies in a caste-ridden society. Kawade is sharp here, and the book



The arrow and the abyss

Ankit Kawade's debut work shows how B.R. Ambedkar repurposes Nietzsche's concept against hierarchical order

walks a fine line between illuminating Nietzsche's appropriation and inadvertently lending it more philosophical dignity than it deserves. The book explores the *Manusmriti*, the ancient Brahminical code that Nietzsche praised as an antidote to Christian conformity and that Ambedkar publicly burned at Mahad on Christmas Day, 1927. Kawade's

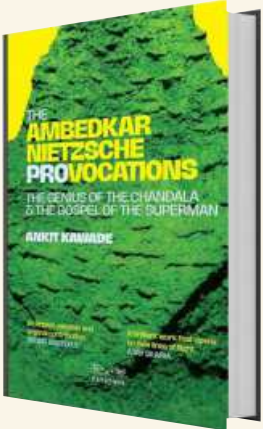
examination shows how the same text can simultaneously be a resource and a ruin: a manual of nobility to one reader while being a cudgel of oppression to another. The section on Ambedkar's constitutionalism, particularly his insistence that he was "not a modern Manu," is arguably the book's most original political contribution, situating Ambedkar not merely as an anti-caste activist

but as a thinker who had to ask what kind of law a liberated society legitimately requires. In an era when ancient legal texts are once again being mobilised as political instruments, the questions Kawade raises are not merely academic.

The most persuasive move
Kawade reads Ambedkar as a careful, combative reader of Nietzsche, not dismissing him

▶ The book explores the *Manusmriti*, which Nietzsche praised and Ambedkar burned. (GETTY IMAGES)

wholesale but exposing the class and caste assumptions buried beneath the aristocratic individualism. The inversion that closes the book is elegant and deserves to be dwelt upon: if Nietzsche diagnosed Christianity as slave morality, Kawade argues that Ambedkar's framework reveals Brahminism itself as yet another form of slave morality. A ruling order that requires the perpetual degradation of others to sustain its own sense of greatness is, by Nietzsche's own criteria, driven by resentment. This is the book's most persuasive move, and the one most likely to unsettle readers who have approached either thinker in isolation. It is also reason enough to read it.



The Ambedkar-Nietzsche Provocations: The Genius of the Chandala and the Gospel of the Superman
Ankit Kawade
Navayana
₹499

Kawade moves fluently from Nietzsche's aphoristic maxims to Ambedkar's constitutional writings. There is a determined singularity that is also on occasion a limitation. The critical question the book must answer for any engaged reader is whether centering the analysis on Nietzsche illuminates Ambedkar or risks Europeanising him. There are moments where the Nietzschean scaffolding seems to dominate the structure when the Ambedkarite argument is entirely capable of standing on its own terms. And yet, perhaps, this is to mistake the book's intent. Nietzsche, in *The Antichrist*, states, "The 'holy lie' – common to Confucius, the law of Manu, Mohammed, the Christian church – is not absent in Plato. 'Truth is there': this means, wherever it is announced, the priest lies." In Nietzsche's view, such lies were meant to wrest control over the minds of the credulous. But what then of truth? Francis Bacon, opening his essay *Of Truth*, recounts, "What is truth? said jesting Pilate, and would not stay for an answer." Both men gesture at the same metaphysical abyss. Ambedkar, however, had no patience for the abyss. In *Annihilation of Caste*, he wrote: "Equality may be a fiction, but nonetheless one must accept it as the governing principle." It is the reply of a man who has read the *Manusmriti* not as a philosopher in repose but as someone it was written to destroy. In the spirit of the Buddhist parable of the poisoned arrow, Ambedkar understood that contemplating the metaphysics of the arrow is a luxury available only to those not already dying.

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New and improved formats
In India, the new bookstore is smaller, more curated, more local, and increasingly assisted by cafés, events, or other sources of support. Offering tactile shopping experiences that are missing online, these stores often focus on speciality formats. Take Fictionary, the fiction-only bookstore in Bandra West, Mumbai. “I’m seeing a lot of independent bookstores coming up in India now. It’s not by default an easy business [especially at a time when Kindle readership is increasing],” says Anup Jain, who started Fictionary a little over 18 months ago. “At the same time, post COVID, Crossword turned profitable and is now expanding like crazy. Bahrison’s [a family-run business in Delhi] is branching out into every other city, and I heard that Relay could be expanding outside of airport spaces, into retail outlets,” he adds.

Passion projects
Interestingly, many independent bookstores are also founded by people who are not traditional booksellers. Vineetha Vijaykumar left 17 years in software to open Turning Pages in north Bengaluru two months ago. Jain of Fictionary came to bookselling after more than a decade in e-commerce. Ramkumar of Printed Matter left a career in climate and sustainability. Almost none of them describe the decision as a straightforward business move. “Nobody is opening a bookstore for profit,” says Rahul Dixit, senior

IS IT INDIA'S BOOKSTORE MOMENT?



Literary festivals help awareness go up. And while there is some enthusiasm after the event [it isn't sustained]. Perhaps it's happening online, but not on-ground. To make real change happen, it would be great to see literary festivals collaborate with local, independent bookstores for smaller year-long events. It's consistency that will bring long-lasting change

MOHIT BATRA
Rajat Book House

'Readers are price conscious'
Amazon's deep discounting has quietly reset what many Indian readers think a book should cost. Neha Pipraiya, who has run Pagdandi bookstore in Pune for 13 years with her husband Vishal, says, “Every day, we have customers showing us online prices.” New bookstores may be photogenic and culturally alive, but online discounts remain the benchmark against which their shelves are judged. As Harshita Varma, a reader from Jaipur, puts it: “Light readers are very price

vice-president of sales at HarperCollins India. “Most also have strong support from a coffee shops [and the like]”. Which is not a bad thing. Landmark and Crossword had already taught Indian readers to linger in bookshops, and café-bookstore combinations are not new either. What feels newer is the degree to which the hybrid model is no longer an add-on,

but a condition of survival. The store now has to be a destination, an aesthetic, a neighbourhood experience and often a social-media object before it can hope to be a viable bookselling business. “The bookstore right now [in India] is not just about selling books. I can't compete with Amazon on price. If I optimised purely for retail, nobody would come,” says Jain. Instead,



The cost equation

In a metro, the infrastructure would cost anywhere between ₹30 and ₹40 lakh. And for a premium bookstore, it would go up to ₹60 lakh. “They have to buy inventory. And though you can do it in phases, what you stock at any point comes to around ₹40-₹50 lakh,” explains Jain of Fictionary. When he started his Bandra bookstore, he spent over ₹1 crore.

conscious. They're more likely to go to a discounted chain or pick up a pre-loved book or order it online.” So publishing pressures remain? Ashwita Jayakumar, co-founder of Indian Summer Press, shares that the standard trade discount built into nearly all publishing contracts makes it difficult for independent presses like hers to find a level playing field. Publishers supply copies to distributors at a

standard discount of 52% – meaning more than half the cover price can disappear before the book even reaches a shelf. That, in turn, affects bookstores: the smaller the margin left in the chain, the less room there is for booksellers to absorb costs, offer discounts, or take risks on slower-moving titles. From what remains, bookstores may still have to offer customers a discount of their own.

Hidden distribution hurdles

Distribution remains a big fault line in India, and it runs unevenly across geography. In Fort Kochi, Ramkumar says she used to struggle with “getting the books I wanted from the distributor”. Her solution: “I would send a list of 50, so I could get 13 or 15.” In Bengaluru, Aashti Mudnani of Lightroom explains the structural difference plainly. “Our access to books is not like being in Delhi. The problem is that warehousing is limited in the city, and so the books are coming from Delhi or abroad, as the case may be.” Recently, she had ordered 150 copies each of 15 titles. About 30 days into it, Lightroom was informed that some of the books “still haven't come” and the distributors weren't sure if they would be available.

Even from the publishing side, the bias is acknowledged. Dixit says that servicing independent bookstores is easier in cities such as Bengaluru, Chennai, Hyderabad, Mumbai and Kolkata than in farther-flung places, and that the concentration of new stores in certain metros is not accidental. A lot depends, he says, on service levels. For younger, smaller indies, it is not easy.



(Clockwise from left) Ukiyo in Imphal, Turning Pages, and Dragonfly Reads in Bengaluru. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

According to data analytics platform Grand View Horizon, India is the fastest growing regional market in Asia Pacific. Its books market generated revenue of approximately \$10.4 million in 2025, and is expected to reach \$17 million by 2033, growing at a CAGR (Compound Annual Growth Rate) of 6.3%.

Offline stores support new authors
But there is good news. Sayantan Ghosh, publishing director at Simon & Schuster India, says that despite the 60/40 ratio between online and offline sales, publishers are trying far more on bookstores today than before. That support, he says, can be regional and specific. “A certain title that may have an appeal in the South [for instance] will get a lot of support from the local bookstores,” he explains. Online, the chance of discovering a new title is “almost zero”. For publishers without infinite marketing budgets, and for books by new authors without blockbuster visibility, the hand-selling and physical display offered by bookstores remain commercially consequential in a way the algorithm often is not. “The independent, passion-driven stores get good support from publishers because they help new authors, new voices and new ideas. It works for both

sides,” adds Dixit of HarperCollins.

The mall advantage
Of course, the ability to survive long enough to do that – help new authors and new books – depends on a very particular economics of space. Ramkumar of Printed Matter is succinct: “Owning the space changes everything.” Many legacy stores endure because they own their premises. In a metro such as Bengaluru, commercial rents for a mid-sized bookstore can range from about ₹1.5 lakh a month in less popular areas to as much as ₹5 lakh in high-footfall neighbourhoods. Security deposits can run to three to six months' rent.

Malls, surprisingly, offer some relief. “They are expensive properties, but they give very friendly terms to the bookstores,” says Dixit. “Because having a bookstore adds a lot of value to the platform of retail that [a mall] can offer.” A chain such as Crossword would get into a mall “at a much lower rate” than another retailer. But this advantage is mostly for large chains because for them “to set up a new store, the cost is very low”, he explains. “Fixtures out of one store can be used somewhere else. And stock is already available.” For an independent, setting up a shop on the same terms would be more difficult.

Younger buyers who want to linger
Today, the profile of the bookstore visitor has shifted. “For the first time, we're finding that people are actually coming in and not just buying and leaving immediately,” says Aashti Mudnani of Lightroom, a specialised children's bookstore in Bengaluru. “They



RAHUL DIXIT
Senior VP of sales, HarperCollins

The independent, passion-driven stores get good support from publishers because they help new authors, new voices and new ideas

are now coming because they have 'read about us or seen us on Instagram', and stay for hours.”

Encouragingly, the age profile of the visitor has changed too, especially with books gaining a 'cool' status driven by social media influencers. In Gangtok, Ramana Shrestha of Rachna Books says 70% to 80% of his visitors are under 30. “They may not have [huge] spending power, but they are the ones who most frequently visit the bookstore and buy,” Anuj Bahri of Bahrison's, too, says that the people walking into his stores today – where literary fiction and narrative non-fiction do well – are largely between 18 and 35.

As Jain of Fictionary puts it, “Previously, there was no channel where books were being marketed. Now, there are bookstagrammers, and so

people are more aware of books. [Romantasy, in particular, was doing very well last year.] It's part of their profile now. Some also want to show off that they're reading, and are buying books as a decor item – to have a good-looking bookshelf at home.”

This makes the moment encouraging but difficult to read. There is evidence of real consumer growth in books in India. In its annual international market report released last year, NielsenIQ BookData and GfK Entertainment state that India is the strongest-growing market among the 18 territories analysed (such as the U.K., France, Australia, and Brazil), with revenue growth of 27%.

But, as Dixit says, “Online remains the majority”, and out of every 100 books sold, 60 to 70 are sold online. The full picture, he adds, is missing when platforms such as Blinkit, which have pulled books into the quick-commerce space, do not share data, and “a lot of online sales are happening through social media channels”.

It's no wonder legacy booksellers are cautious about calling this a “bookstore comeback” when the picture is more complicated than rising footfalls or new openings. Bookstores in India are certainly undergoing a transformation, with new stores more deliberate about their audience, and more hybrid. Let's just hope they are being rebuilt into something that might have a shot at surviving.

The writer is an editor and independent journalist based in Delhi.



Creating third spaces

Swati Daftuar

The bookstore is, increasingly, not simply shops. For many readers, such as Maryann Taylor in Gurugram, the draw has everything to do with “the interaction that will never happen online”. Founders of independent bookstores are now very intentional about creating third spaces where people can meet, start conversations, linger over a cup of coffee, and participate in a variety of activities.

From Beku, the queer-friendly bookstore in Bengaluru, that hosts everything from book readings to pottery workshops, to Rajar Book Corner in Jaipur, where their Two Pages book club is so popular that regulars stay back to hold space for members waiting to have conversations around difficult topics such as post-partum struggles, grief, and career troubles, bookstores are now becoming important community hubs.



Scan the QR code to read the full story and see some of these community-first spaces.

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty



Saibal Chatterjee

Two exceptional football documentaries unveiled at the 79th Cannes Film Festival have deftly pushed the Beautiful Game beyond the confines of sport and into the realms of history, poetry and psychoanalysis. Argentine directors Juan Cabral and Santiago Franco's *The Match* (*El Partido*) attempts a particularly complex feat. It condenses 220 years of history and geopolitics in a single 90-minute football clash between Argentina and England. Forty years on, that 1986 match is still regarded as one the greatest to be ever played.

The second football film, *Cantona*, made by David Tryhorn and Ben Nicholas, is a deep dive into the mind of the iconic but always controversial Eric Cantona, whose five years at Manchester United in the 1990s went into football folklore for eternity and made him the most gifted French footballer of his generation.

“You are in the story that you create, not in the reality of the world. It is like cinema,” footballer-turned-actor Cantona says on camera as he helps the British directing duo make sense of the perplexing upheavals and career-threatening outbursts that rocked the “fiery” Frenchman. He careened through as many as eight clubs in a decade until Man United and [team manager] Alex Ferguson happened to him.

On the Croisette

Four years in the works, the Cantona documentary forays into the highs and lows of his explosive career, piecing together his action-packed story with the help of interviews with Ferguson, former footballers David Beckham and Guy Roux, and his parents.

This is Cantona's third time in Cannes. He was here as an actor in 2009 with Ken Loach's Competition title, *Looking for Eric*. Five years later, he had a role in

79TH CANNES FILM FESTIVAL MARADONA AND CANTONA SCORE A GOAL

Ahead of the FIFA World Cup in June, two documentaries show how football reflects life and history



Football on the red carpet

- In 2009, Cantona walked the red carpet with Ken Loach's *Looking for Eric*, starring the footballer as himself in a fictional story of a down-and-out middle-aged football-obsessed postman in Manchester who hallucinates about his sporting idol when he's at his lowest.
- Cantona, who had already debuted as an actor in Shekhar Kapur's *Elizabeth* (1998) after hanging up his boots, impersonated the 'spirit' of the cult figure that the down-and-out Mancunian invoked.
- Football has since been a constant presence at Festival de Cannes. *United Passions* premiered in 2014. Funded by FIFA, the film about the founding of the game's governing body, was panned as propaganda.
- Over the years, Cannes has programmed several other football films, including *Pelé Eterno/Pelé Forever* (2005), a two-hour documentary promoted by the Brazilian legend himself; *Maradona by Kusturica* (2008), by Serbian director Emir Kusturica; and *Diego Maradona* (2019), a documentary by British-Indian filmmaker Asif Kapadia.

Kristian Levring's out-of-competition entry *The Salvation*, starring Mads Mikkelsen.

This year, besides the documentary on his life and career, Cantona the actor is in first-time director *Avril*

(Clockwise from left) A still from *The Match*; directors Juan Cabral (right) and Santiago Franco; stills from *Cantona*, and *The Match*; and director David Tryhorn (left) with Eric Cantona in Cannes. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT, GETTY IMAGES)



Besson's *Les Matins Merveilleux*, a film much like the documentary about him. It is playing as part of the festival's Special Screenings section.

Story beyond sports
Neither of the two films is only about football and that is what sets them apart from other sports documentaries. At the presentation of *The Match*, Thierry Fremaux, general delegate, Cannes Film Festival, asserted as much. “This film is not only about football. It is about a whole lot else,” he said. *The Match* played as part of Cannes Premiere, a segment of the festival that includes the latest films of auteurs Volker Schlöndorff, Kiyoshi Kurosawa and Christophe Honoré.

“We set out to make a film that everybody, even those who know nothing about the match, say a woman from Iowa in the U.S., can love,” says Cabral. He and Franco have done just that. *The Match* is both brilliantly cinematic and consistently riveting. It zooms in on the 1986 Argentina-England FIFA World Cup quarter-finals at the Estadio Azteca, Mexico City – a rousing encounter that produced two of the most iconic goals in the annals of the sport, both scored by Diego Maradona around four minutes apart. The first was the much-debated “Hand of God” goal, the next a result of pure genius.

The match was played four years after the Falklands War and the needle in the stands was palpable. On the pitch, bad blood may have strictly been confined to the long footballing rivalry between the two nations but a military conflict still fresh in public memory made the contest more bruising than it otherwise would have been.

“These 22 men out in the middle did not know that they were carrying the burden of history. The huge weight on their backs and shoulders was invisible,” says Cabral. It is this “invisible” burden that *The Match* maps, with a lot of drama and emotion thrown in. It has several players – Jorge Valdano, Jorge Burruchaga, Ricardo Giusti, Julio Olarticoechea and Oscar Ruggeri from Argentina; Gary Lineker, Peter Shilton and John

Barnes from England – sharing their thoughts and memories of what unfolded that memorable evening.

Four decades on
Franco, whose association with the film began when friend Cabral gifted him a book on the 1986 World Cup match on his birthday, says: “When we started to think about the approaching 40th anniversary of the match, we knew we had no time to waste. The making of the film was, therefore, extremely intense. It was non-stop work for a year and a half.”

Every step of the way, the film demanded complete absorption and focus. “When you make a documentary, it has to be as elegant as Maradona's sublime second goal. You endure the pain of the process because there is something beautiful to be achieved at the end of it,” says Cabral.

Much of the beauty of the film stems from the lively narration provided by Lineker (in English) and Valdano (in Spanish). “Both are kind of philosophers,” says Cabral. “They are amazing storytellers. They have a way with words. Lineker is a superstar on TV while Valdano has written books on football. Getting them on board was a no-brainer.”

The documentary is 91 minutes long, exactly as long as the match it is about. The drama and insight that it delivers is far more than an hour and a half of the film's runtime.

Both Cabral and Franco say that *The Match* is an important film because it is about the sport and because it “exceeds football”.

Would the film have been any different had Maradona been alive? “Maradona is ever present in *The Match*,” says Franco. “For us, he isn't gone. He is still very much around. Towards the end, there is a message – clear and transparent. There is no justice in football and there is no justice in life,” adds Cabral. “You either try to overcome the situation through humanity and humour or you go to war, which makes no sense at all.”

The writer is a New Delhi-based film critic.



There is an expression my late father would use: “*Avan enna periya pista?*” Literal translation: “Is he a big pista?” *Pista*, in colloquial Tamil, means ‘don’ or ‘big shot’. A powerful person. Appa had a rebellious streak. He used to say, “There are two kinds of people. *Pistas* and cockroaches. *Pistas* are few but look after each other. The cockroaches are many but are divided. Cockroaches are more loyal to one or the other *pista* than to other cockroaches. That's why *pistas* will always rule over cockroaches.” Growing up in Chennai, that was my only sense of the word ‘*pista*’.

After I moved to Delhi as a teenager, my understanding of ‘*pista*’ expanded. Every year, around Diwali, a stream of visitors would come home to meet Appa, bearing packages of nuts they insisted on calling ‘dry fruits’. These typically had a mix of walnuts, almonds, cashew, raisins, and a shelled nut called ‘pista’ (pistachio).

A nutty rivalry
Over the years, I developed a tremendous appetite for roasted cashews. I ritualistically gorged myself on them when I needed comfort food. But recently, it was brought to my notice that my health, like our economy, is going down the tube and for much the same reasons: neglect, idiotic choices. My mindless snacking – especially the vast quantities of cashew I down – was ruining my gut.

“If you love nuts so much,” my gastroenterologist said, “switch to pista.” “Why is pista better than *kaju*?” “Less carbs, higher protein, more fibre,” he said. “Also, having to shell each pista will slow you down, reduce overall consumption.” Thanks to 10-minute delivery, three packets of pista were waiting for me when I got back from the gastro visit. I took Katta's

ex-cookie jar and made it my pista jar.

Joys of ‘laughing’

The gastro was right. The shelling added considerable friction to my ease of snacking. Nonetheless, transitioning from cashews to pistas proved easier than expected. My favourite were the ‘laughing’ pistas that revealed a bit of the kernel. They were easy to open. But there were always a few that wouldn't open no matter what. When I tried breaking the shell with a hammer, my desk cracked, not the pistas. Those were some tough nuts.

For five days after the switch, all went well. My calorie count dropped. I slept better. On the sixth day, as I dipped my fingers into the pista jar, all I came up with were empty shells. The jar was still half-full. I emptied it on the floor and patiently sifted through hundreds of pistas. All turned out to be hollow shells. Not one kernel. Somebody had polished off my pistas and put the empty shells back in the jar. I was incensed. Who would do such an evil thing? Can't a man even eat pistas in peace in this country anymore? I confronted Katta. He

denied any wrongdoing. “Who else could have done it?” I thundered. “Ask grandma,” he said. My mother was diabetic. She had a weakness for every kind of nut, including the Big One. But she, too, denied “touching” my pistas. “Are you nuts?” she cried, indignant. “I don't even go to your study.”

“But someone's been eating my pistas,” I said. “Ask his mother,” my mother said, nodding at Katta.

The fault in our stars
That evening, I politely ventured to ask Wife. “Do you, by any chance, happen to know if anyone's been eating my pistas?”

“Yes. I had a few.” “You did?” I was speechless. “And the shells? Instead of dumping them in the waste basket, you put them back in my jar? You did that?” “The waste basket on your desk is perpetually overflowing,” she said. “I've been telling you to empty them for years now. Anyway, I don't litter. So, I put the shells in the only container available on your table.”

I stood there marvelling at how, magically, the whole thing had become my fault. I knew better than to prolong this conversation. So, I started dragging my pista jar. The only problem: I don't always remember to hide it after snacking. When I don't, the next time I open it, I find only empty shells.

Sometimes, my fingers land on a kind-looking pista, its mouth parted ever so slightly, as if it's about to tell you its *Mamm ki Baat*. You look at its face, and you're convinced there's a juicy kernel tucked inside. You eagerly prise it open. But all you find is dust. It's these duplicitous pistas that make me really angry. But it's a pista. Nothing I can do about it. I am just a cockroach.

G. Sampath of this satire is Social Affairs Editor, The Hindu.

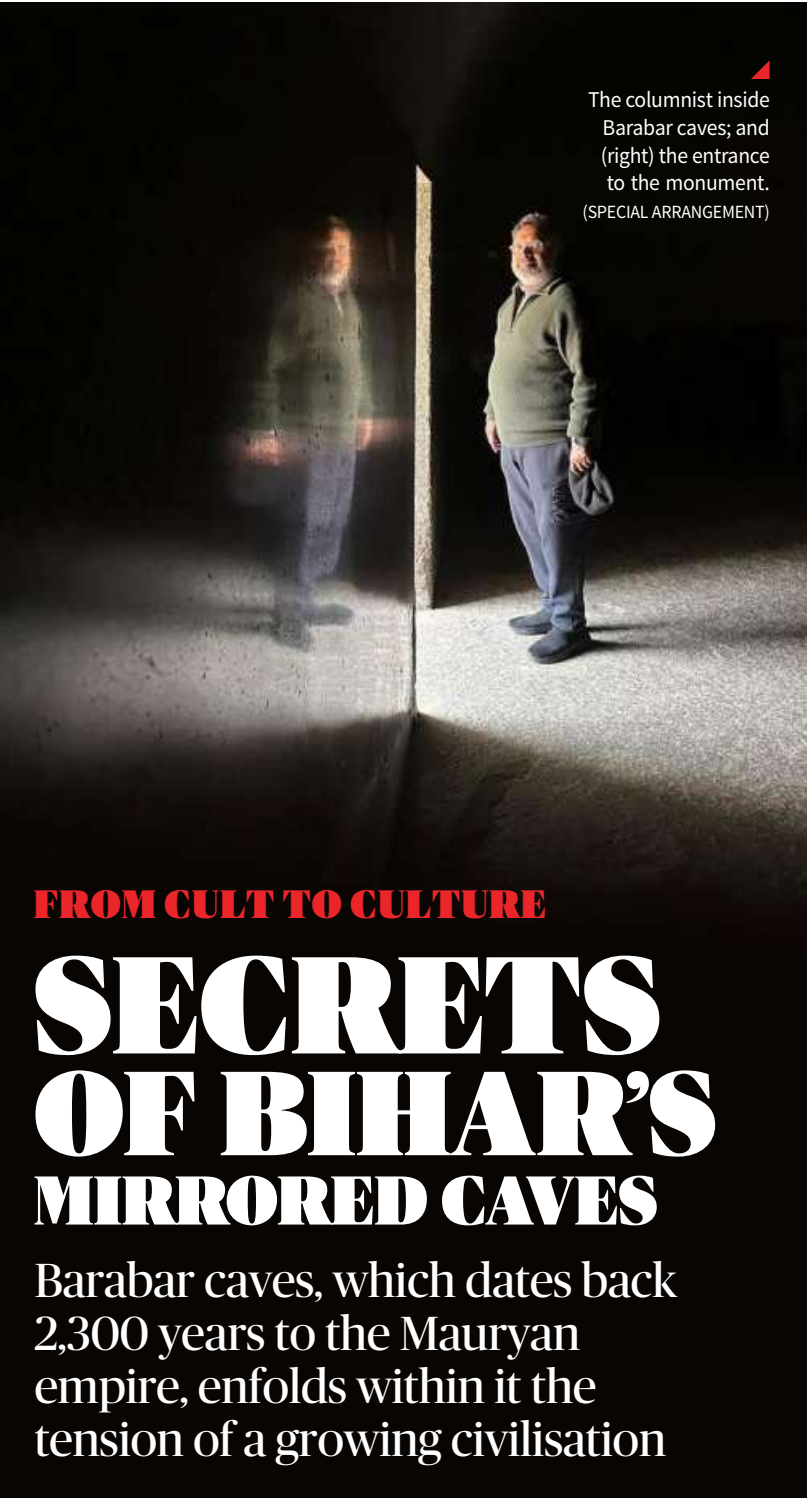
One of the most striking experiences near Rajgir in Bihar lies inside the Barabar caves. The walls are polished to such perfection that they are like mirrors. These surfaces were carved and finished over 2,300 years ago, yet they still reflect light with startling clarity, as if time has barely touched them. This sheen, often described as Mauryan polish, hints at how the pillars of Maurya kings once looked – smooth, luminous, and authoritative.

The Barabar caves are among the oldest surviving monuments in India, yet they rarely occupy public imagination. They stand overshadowed by the more celebrated Ashoka pillars, crowned with lions and inscribed with imperial messages. But the caves tell a quieter, more complex story.

These are not monuments of conquest or governance; they were spaces dedicated to a group of hermits known as the Ajivikas. This is known because inscriptions in early Brahmi script are carved onto the cave walls. Ironically, the script appears rough, even intrusive, against the flawless polish of the stone, as if human language struggled to match the perfection of the surface it marked.

The entrance to the caves resemble gateways seen later in Buddhist sites, with a line of elephants bowing towards a stupa-like form. At the ends are elephant-headed fish, the ancient fertility symbol known as Makara. These are probably the earliest images of elephants in India.

When an empire formed
Geographically, the caves stand in a region of great historical importance. Rajgir was one of the



The columnist inside Barabar caves; and (right) the entrance to the monument. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)

FROM CULT TO CULTURE

SECRETS OF BIHAR'S MIRRORED CAVES

Barabar caves, which dates back 2,300 years to the Mauryan empire, enfolds within it the tension of a growing civilisation



earliest centres of monarchy in the subcontinent. This was also the landscape where elephants were domesticated and iron technology was first explored at scale. It allowed chieftains to expand control over land and people.

What once must have been small, scattered communities began to consolidate into larger political units. These leaders became toll collectors, managing trade routes and accumulating wealth. This process contributed to the rise of the Mauryan Empire around 2,300 years ago.

Trade routes expanded dramatically during this time. Networks stretched from the Ganga plains to the eastern coast, the western shores, and the northern mountains. Elephants played a crucial role in this expansion. They navigated uneven terrain, cleared dense vegetation, and opened pathways through flooded or forested regions. In doing so, they enabled the creation of routes along

which goods, people, and ideas could move. These developments marked one of the earliest phases of economic intensification in India, when older pastoral systems had already begun to give way to settled agriculture.

This economic transformation was accompanied by a philosophical churn. The period is often remembered for the rise of Buddhism and Jainism, but other traditions were equally significant. Among them were the Ajivikas, to whom these caves were dedicated. The term Ajivika suggested people without livelihood (*jivika*, in Prakrit). They rejected social ties, property, and even clothing. Known also as Nigranthas, meaning “without knots”, they avoided attachments of all kinds. They wandered naked, detached from family and society, and pursued a severe path of renunciation. Their goal was stark: to overcome hunger and desire, gradually withdrawing from the

world, even to the point of death by fasting.

Standing in opposition
At the other extreme stood the Charvakas. Their name was linked to grazing (*chara*), suggesting indulgence and consumption. They embraced material life, arguing that the purpose of existence lay in sensory pleasure. They dismissed concerns about debt, duty, or consequences. If the Ajivikas sought to extinguish desire, the Charvakas chose to celebrate it.

These opposing views emerged in a society increasingly shaped by ideas of accounting and exchange. As trade expanded, people became familiar with concepts of credit and debit. These financial ideas gradually influenced moral thinking, giving rise to notions of spiritual balance, such as *paap* (sin) and *punya* (virtue). Yet, both Ajivikas and Charvakas stood apart from this framework. One rejected the world entirely; the other refused to moralise it.

The Barabar caves captured this moment of transition. They were carved under the patronage of a powerful king who sought to extend political control while also seeking spiritual merit. By offering these caves to renunciants who rejected the world, the ruler participated in a paradox – material power supported those who denied material life. In that tension lay the foundations of a civilisation negotiating wealth, renunciation, desire, and transcendence.



Devdutt Pattanaik is the author of 50 books on mythology, art and culture.

GOREN BRIDGE
Careless play
Both vulnerable, East deals

Bob Jones
North's second double showed extra values in a hand that could not raise spades. South might have bid four diamonds instead of four spades, but it was reasonable to take a shot at game. East won the opening heart lead and continued the suit. South ruffed, led a low spade to dummy's ace, and a spade back to his jack. West took his

queen and led another heart, which South had to ruff. South cashed the king of spades, his last trump, and ran his clubs. West ruffed the fifth club and led a diamond. South had to lose a diamond trick and finished down one. South did not play this hand properly. Can you spot what he did wrong?
South should have expected that the hearts would split 6-3 after this bidding. He should simply have discarded a diamond at

trick two instead of ruffing. He could then ruff the third heart and play the spades the same way. This time, when West won his queen, he would have no heart to lead. West would shift to a diamond, but South should play dummy's ace and cross to his hand with the queen of clubs. The king-jack of spades would draw the trumps and allow both of dummy's remaining diamonds to be discarded. South could then claim with all good clubs in dummy.

NORTH
♠ A 7
♥ 9 6 5
♦ A Q 9
♣ A K J 9 2

WEST
♠ Q 9 5 3
♥ J 7 2
♦ 7 3
♣ 10 8 7 5

EAST
♠ 6 4
♥ A K Q 10 8 4
♦ K 10 8 5
♣ 3

SOUTH
♠ K J 10 8 2
♥ 3
♦ J 6 4 2
♣ Q 6 4

The bidding:
EAST 1♥
SOUTH Pass
WEST 2♥
NORTH Dbl
WEST 3♥
NORTH Dbl
WEST All pass

Opening lead: Two of ♥

QUIZ
Easy like Sunday morning

Units unite!



Born on May 24, 1686, this physicist was responsible for popularising the mercury-filled thermometer. GETTY IMAGES

Berty Ashley

Born on May 24, 1686, Daniel Gabriel ____ was a physicist who was responsible for popularising the mercury-filled thermometer. This also led to widespread use of the scale he developed, eventually making his name synonymous with a unit of measurement. Who was this scientist?

Michael ____ was responsible for advancing the understanding of electromagnetism. His work led to the development and widespread use of electric motors, which play a massive role in modern technology. As a result, the SI unit of capacitance was named after him. If the unit

is ‘farad’, what is his name?

The ‘gal’ is a unit of acceleration used in the study and measurement of gravity. Quite aptly, it is named after a scientist who proved a very important aspect of gravity. Name the scientist.

Alexander Graham Bell's wife and mother were both deaf, which influenced his research on sound. This work eventually led to a unit of measurement being named after him. That unit is rarely used today, but its derivative, equal to one-tenth of its value, is very common. Which unit is this?

This particular unit is no longer in use. It was originally defined as the energy

contained in one mole of photons. Fittingly, it was named after the scientist who won the Nobel Prize for his work on the photoelectric effect. Which iconic scientist's name is now an obsolete unit?

The unit femtometre (fm) is equal to 10⁻¹⁵ metre, or a quadrillionth of one metre. The name comes from the Danish word *femten* (fifteen). It is also known by another name derived from a physicist who created the first nuclear reactor. Which scientist's name is also used for this unit?

This unit represents the amount of radioactive material that undergoes 37 billion nuclear decays per second. The unit is unique in that it is named

after two people, and unfortunately, one of them died from the very phenomenon the unit measures. What is the unit?

This scale is no longer widely used in science, but it remains highly prevalent in popular culture and everyday usage. It is the measure of the strength of a natural phenomenon and largely has been replaced with the ‘moment magnitude scale’. What was the original scale, named after a seismologist?

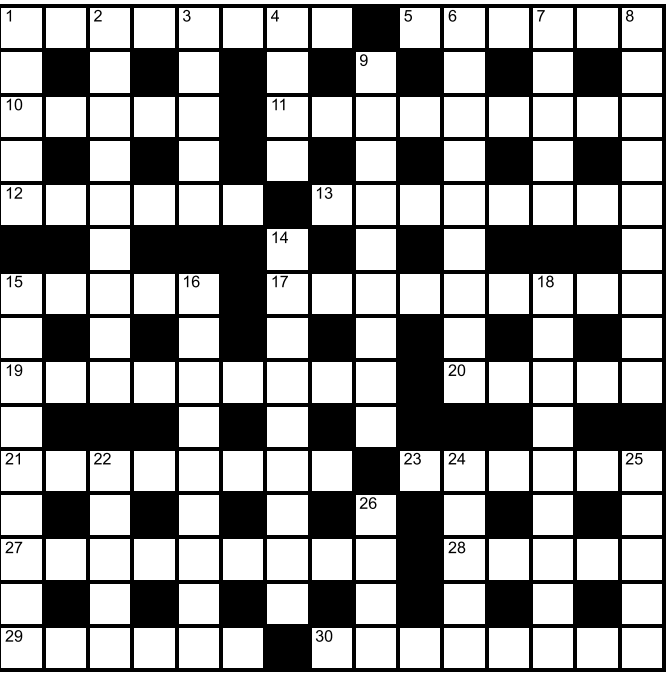
The ‘XY’ scale is a measure of a material's indentation hardness, meaning how well it performs under load. It was developed by brothers Hugh XY and Stanley XY, after whom it is named. What is XY, which can also describe something that is hard (X) and how it performs in this test (Y)?

The Scoville scale is named after pharmacist Wilbur Scoville, who devised it for his company. He created the scale by measuring the amount of capsaicin in a certain vegetables. What does this scale measure?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called ‘Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion’.
@bertyashley

1. Daniel Gabriel Fahrenheit
2. Michael Faraday
3. Galileo Galilei
4. Decibel (dB)
5. Albert Einstein
6. Enrico Fermi
7. Curie (Ci)
8. Richter scale
9. Rockwell
10. Spiciness or heat level of chili peppers
- Answers**

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 57 (Set by Incognito)



- Across**
1 Friend confirms as true and talks (8)
5 Churchman tense, perhaps, taking gold (6)
10 Eva is chaperoned to some extent (5)
11 Toy Papa put down before night shift (9)
12 Poetry collection includes old names (6)
13 Legendary land at end of tunnel is giving shelter to soldier (8)
15 President's joke about sex appeal backfired (5)
17 Equine sounds by boy, our next door resident (9)
19 Something said to wish luck to an actor, but perhaps not to a dancer (5,1,3)
20 Lowest point for king (5)
21 Mom's diet can be bold (8)
23 Cutting loafs and putting in a bit of fresh variety meats (6)
27 Making speed, consumes gin cocktail around 10 (9)
28 Afterwards, large rat having energy jumped (5)
29 Most coy literary moneylender loses security device near estate (6)
30 Right drain remodelled by Ohio physicist at first to get a bit of liquid precipitation? (8)

- Down**
1 Things Sherlock Holmes had used by plumbers (5)
2 Gentler to adjust eyeglasses (9)
3 VP's vehicle is in front of church (5)
4 Some peri-peri peppers may be ready to eat (4)
6 Confusing a star, Khan produces lambskin with

- curled wool (9)
7 What Oliver may do with someone's arm? (5)
8 Hospital employee? May be a government officer... (9)
9 Separate long and narrow elevation for bird (9)
14 A client is strangely rigid (9)
15 Proclaims: “Bar that lady in large part of isle” (9)
16 Sends Ken a design showing nudity (9)
18 Skilled painter of yore turned almost red (3,6)
22 Cluttered eating place at yard (5)
24 Fighter joins Musk to manufacture Su-57 for NATO (5)
25 Belt parts recycled (5)
26 Alcoholics Anonymous covers Greek city (4)

SOLUTION NO. 56



The punch of a smile

The anatomy behind a gesture that keeps human connections humming

Tiny Nair
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The triceps on the back of your hand weighs about a kilogram, has a cross-sectional area of 25 square cm, and can deliver up to 2,000 newtons of force in a single punch, enough to break the jawbone of a challenging opponent in a boxing ring. In contrast, the small zygomaticus, a muscle attached to your cheekbone, weighing around a gram and with a cross-sectional area of just 0.1 square cm, generates a force of 1 newton when it contracts, pulling up the angle of your mouth and producing a smile. Brute power grabs the spotlight, while a cute smile hides behind the curtain.

As another World Laughter Day passed on May 3, let us look at how a cute smile stacks up against strong-arm tactics.

Evolution of smile

After nine long months of lugging the weight in her protruding abdomen, marked by bouts of nausea and vomiting, and finally the excruciating labour pain, the mother receives a gift of a wet, howling lifeform. Her first reciprocation, a social smile by the sixth week, magically changes everything. The mother falls for it, and the baby quickly learns to use it as her best defensive tool to disarm the parents when she carries out all his naughty deeds, from broken mementoes to handprints on the wall, simply by offering a cute little smile. It is estimated that a three-year-old child smiles and laughs around 300 times a day, but as she grows into adulthood, this number drops to a meagre 20. By the time a doctor dons the “white coat” and the “black stethoscope”, the number approaches zero. It is often said that “the only doctor who smiles is one who features in the toothpaste ad”.



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

Our neighbour, an elderly man, had been bedridden for a long time. One morning, a small crowd and a black flag in his courtyard confirmed the inevitable: he was no more. I was a medical student and accompanied my parents to his house. People sat in chairs scattered across his front veranda, talking in hushed tones. I noticed two children playing rock-paper-scissors in a corner, occasionally giggling, but no one really cared. Inside the room, the body lay in a glass case, covered with flowers and wreaths. People silently went around, stood for a while, and prayed. A middle-aged gentleman entered, helped by others, suggesting he was perhaps unwell. He looked almost on the brink of tears. Suddenly, he started laughing loudly, looking at the body. It was not a chuckle but belly-busting laughter. Everyone was stunned and taken aback. He was escorted out of the room. I understood that it was very, very inappropriate. A decade later, my professor of medicine would teach me that he was most likely suffering from a neurological disease called pseudobulbar palsy, a condition in which inappropriate bouts of laughter are interspersed with crying as part of the disease. No one thought the giggling children did anything inappropriate, but the adult who laughed was shown the door.

A medical student is thrust into a clinical posting right after learning the basics of anatomy, physiology, and biochemistry. A clinical posting

revolves around rounds and discussions at a patient’s bedside, where the hierarchy is as strict as an army parade. The serious-looking professor converses with the junior staff. Questions fly to the postgraduates, and their every answer is mocked and criticised, while the scared medical students, orbiting close to the Milky Way, get the message loud and clear – this is serious business with no place for humour, a smile, or laughter.

We were taught all the skills to elicit a clinical sign, but were never taught that “appropriate” humour, in the right doses, could make a patient smile or laugh, could create a stronger bond with the patient, and enhance therapeutic benefit, especially in non-critical situations.

But things are changing. Many top medical universities, including Columbia University (New York), McGill University (Montreal), and King’s College London, offer dedicated courses in humour in medicine within their humanities programs. Applying humour in a hospital setting, among suffering and sick people, is not easy, but it is worthwhile; it could improve workplace safety and physician burnout. Now we see a massive increase in the number of gyms and fitness centres in the city, and people flocking to keep themselves in good shape. Let us take an oath that while developing biceps and strengthening triceps, we will not neglect the zygomatic muscles that make us smile better.

Cats, dogs, cows and all others in animal kingdom

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In the past, cattle and other pet animals were integral to village life. Cattle were reared for milk, meat, and agricultural activities. But with increasing mechanisation of agriculture, cattle wealth is on the decline and with that, the bond between other animals and man began getting weakened.

I recall how my house was always abuzz with activity with galloping calves, lactating cows, muscular bulls, pregnant buffaloes, roosters and hen with chicks, goats, dogs and cats. In fact, cattle were regarded as wealth.

Till the 1960s and 1970s, almost every house owned tens of cattle, a dog and a cat. To house the cattle, a separate shed was constructed. Milch and draught cattle were tethered and calves were let off freely.

Unlike now, the dog was not tethered and the cat would freely roam. Poultry birds were kept in coops after sunset when they come for roosting. As a child, every morning my task was to drive off my buffaloes and cows to a village square and hand them over to a cattle herder. He, in turn, takes all the cattle for grazing in the common grazing lands. If a new calf arrives in my house, it was a festival.

We were assigned the task of feeding the calf with tender leaves, giving it water and bathing it on holidays. Tethering the calf after returning from grazing were our other assigned tasks. In this way, we learnt to show empathy towards animals and also learnt the rules of coexistence from childhood days.

Once the mother cow returns from grazing, the calf was tethered by us.

During holidays, we used to play with calves and call them by name. They were just like our family members. When our semi pet dog produced a litter, our joy knew no bound. We learnt to share space with other species. Thus, childhood passed with out any stress.

During milking times, I used to sit by the side of my grandmother with a small tumbler. After milking was over, I used to beg her to fill the tumbler with fresh milk.

Disregarding her advice that drinking raw milk was not good for health, I used to relish it.

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The other day I stepped into a clothing shop with a modest intention. I told myself that this time I would choose something different. The shelves were full of attractive options.

I spent a good deal of time browsing, touching the fabrics, holding a few shirts against my shoulder and examining them in the mirror. After all that careful inspection I walked out with what I usually buy. A blue shirt and a grey pair of trousers. The mildly embarrassing fact is that my wardrobe already contains several blue shirts and more grey trousers than I need. Yet whenever I stand before a wide array of choices, something quietly pulls me towards the same familiar corner.

Later that evening I was scrolling through the contacts on my phone. Over the years, the list has grown quite long. It

The magic of one-fifth

Roughly 20% of the effort often produces 80% of the results



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contains former colleagues, distant relatives, old acquaintances, service providers, and many others whose numbers were once saved with a definite purpose. But when it comes to actual conversations, I realised that I regularly speak only to a small group of them. Perhaps one-fifth of the names receive most of my calls. A few close friends, a couple of family members, and occasionally a colleague.

A similar pattern appears in the kitchen at home.

The world of food offers endless possibilities. Yet, on most mornings, our breakfast quietly returns to a few dependable companions. Idli on some days. Dosa on others. Puttu or Poori when we feel like a slight change. These four dishes probably account for most of our breakfasts.

This curious imbalance has been observed by economists and given a

name. It is called the Pareto Principle. Roughly 20% of the effort often produces 80% of the results. In offices, one may notice that a small portion of the working day generates most of the useful work. Even in our personal lives, a small circle of people provides companionship and emotional support. It is not surprising that 20% of our clothes are worn most of the time, a few dishes dominate our dining table, and only a handful of people remain close to us.

Life does not really demand that we spread ourselves evenly across everything and everyone. Often it is the smaller portion that carries the greater value.

If 20% of our time gives 80% efficiency, it may be worth paying attention to how we spend that small but productive slice of the day. If 20% of the people in our lives give us 80% of our warmth, laughter and comfort, then those few relationships deserve our very best attention.

The old summers of contentment

Back then, vacations were meant for travel, visiting relatives, and reading

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When I was a child, my father quietly introduced me to the habit of reading by bringing home a newspaper every day. During summer vacations, we would gather the weekly children’s supplements from past issues and bind them into a single book. Those bound pages felt



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like a treasure.

Now, I find myself sharing those same stories with my child. In those moments, the past gently meets the present.

Summer vacations, in those days, were never meant to be spent in one place. They were a time for visiting grandparents, cousins, uncles, and aunts. Each visit carried a quiet excitement, and every

farewell came with affection, often in the form of a new dress or a small sum of money slipped into our hands. I would travel to my father’s cousins, who lived in a small town, while my cousins from our native village would come to our home, which lies somewhere in between.

The days unfolded with visits to temples, outings to dams and parks, and the occasional climb up a small hill. In the village, we made *pananga vandi* (a small cart made from palmyra fruit) and raced them with great seriousness, carefully tying knots so they would not come undone. At a friend’s house, glasses of fresh juice offered sweet relief from the heat.

We did not have many toys, but we never felt their absence. *Goli* (marbles), paper balls tied with rubber bands, and a restless imagination were

enough to fill our days. A bath at the pumpset was both play and refreshment. At night, we would spread mats in the open and lie under the sky, talking until sleep quietly took over.

Village life had its own quiet richness. Fresh milk straight from the cow and small, thoughtful treats made everything special.

As children, we did not always recognise the value of those days. Today, many children spend their summers in structured camps, learning new skills and routines. While such experiences have their place, they cannot quite replace the warmth of relationships, shared laughter, and the unspoken comfort of being surrounded by family. Summer vacations were never just a break. They were, in their own gentle way, lessons in life, love, and belonging.



FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

The Venice Biennale arrives in a world saturated with images of war, displacement and quiet psychological fatigue as a rare architecture of collective reflection. ('Why this Venice Biennale matters'; May 17.) The art exhibition is a global language that translates crisis into form, silence and imagination.

Vijay Singh Adhikari

Community focus

Kader Attia is an interesting choice as the seventh Kochi-Muziris Biennale's curator. ('Kader Attia's dream for Kochi'; May 17.) His emphasis on interstitial spaces and collective practice, not celebrity-driven spectacle, is a welcome direction. Whether that translates meaningfully in Kochi's sociopolitical landscape will depend on genuine community engagement, not just curatorial intent.

Abbharna Barathi

New reading trend

Pranavi Sharma's article highlights that Indian readers are gravitating towards 'slim' books that compress large amounts of knowledge. ('Why India is turning to slim non-fiction books'; May 17.) Indian publishers should significantly boost the production of slim non-fiction titles.

A. Myilsami
Fazalu Rahman

Climate action

The book review has piqued my interest. ('Against the velocity of modern life'; May 17.) Public awareness of individuals' role in combating climate change isn't at a desirable level. People can resist the hyper-accelerated pace of life, slow down by adopting a lifestyle more compatible with preserving the Earth and natural ecosystems.

Kosaraju Chandramouli

The legacy

For Indians growing up with 2000s TV, Discovery Channel and Morris's programmes became a first window into anthropology and human behaviour. ('Desmond Morris: The controversial zoologist'; May 17.) Morris showed that understanding human biology through science encourages maturity, empathy and self-awareness rather than moral decline.

Harsh Pawaria



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A quantity-driven mindset

People have more information today at their fingertips but are incapable of assessing a truth from a lie

Sundar S. Nathan

Creation and destruction

The dichotomy creates an inflexion point where the human intelligence stands challenged

Sharada Natarajan

Finding joy in one's own company

Depending on friends for happiness is wrong, because in doing so, you lose yourself

Piyush Goel

Paradise found

Far away from the crowded beaches of Goa lies a secluded beach nurturing the marvels of nature

Aakash Bajpai

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